

FALLING DOWN, STANDING UP Naseeruddin Shah stars as Rushdie in the adaptation

PLAY ▲

TRAUMA TO THEATRE

Co-director Arghya Lahiri on working with Naseeruddin Shah on Salman Rushdie's memoir *Knife* for a stage adaptation

Adapting a devastating memoir about violence, recovery and resilience for the stage is no easy feat. It takes an actor of Naseeruddin Shah's calibre to bring Salman Rushdie's *Knife: Meditations After an Attempted Murder*, to life as a stage adaptation. Shah plays Rushdie in the play *27 Seconds* for the Prithvi Festival and directs it too, with co-director Arghya Lahiri.

"Naseer reached out to Mr Rushdie directly for the rights," says Lahiri, adding that the latter responded with great enthusiasm and understanding. "It was not difficult at all. I think it helps, of course, that it is Naseer," he says. Rushdie has publicly spoken about his admiration for the actor.

The play, dramatised by Shah alongside veteran director Kaushik Sen, doesn't attempt a word-for-word retelling of the book. Instead, it seeks to capture its emotional residue. "It's like that Anthony Minghella (British filmmaker) quote about *The Talented Mr. Ripley* where he says, 'You flush the book through your mouth and then you try and put down the taste that's left'," he says. What remains on stage is a meditation on resilience and freedom of expression. "My belief is that it allowed Mr Rushdie to draw a line under not just the attack, but the 33 years since the fatwa," reflects Lahiri.

Directing with an icon like Shah might sound daunting, but Lahiri sees his role as simply being the "first audience" in the room. "I'm there to help him realise this vision," he shares. Lahiri hopes Rushdie gets to see the play sometime. "If faith conspires that he gets to watch it, that would be wonderful indeed," he signs off. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

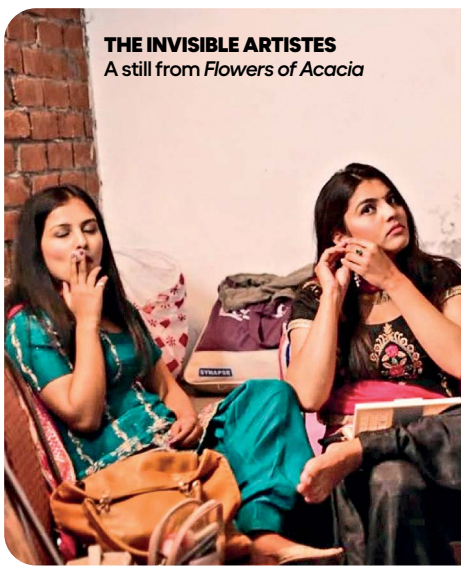
The show will be staged on Nov. 2 and 3, and from Nov. 24-Dec. 6 at Prithvi Theatre, Mumbai, before heading to Chandigarh, Delhi and Bengaluru

BOOKS ▼

Behind The Screen

KHALID MOHAMED, ONE OF INDIA'S BEST-KNOWN SHOWBIZ JOURNALISTS, WRITES ABOUT A LIFETIME OF BRUSHING SHOULDERS WITH THE WHO'S WHO OF BOLLYWOOD

Over countless interviews and two biographies—Asha Parekh's *The Hit Girl* and Amitabh Bachchan's *To Be Or Not To Be*—Khalid Mohamed has proven his mastery at getting celebrities to reveal themselves. With *Not Quite Family*, Mohamed is finally stepping out into the spotlight and saying, "My turn!".



THE INVISIBLE ARTISTES A still from *Flowers of Acacia*

A makeshift Punjab wedding stage. A young woman sways before 50 men, many of them high, several leering. To them, she is indispensable décor. To a boy in Kauloke village, she was something else. "As a child, when